

Standard Terms of Reference for Area-Based Coordination

(endorsed by the IASC Humanitarian Working Group, March 2026)

Background

Wherever possible, coordination of responses to humanitarian needs should be led by national and local actors, including, but not limited to, States, which have the responsibility, first and foremost, to take care of the victims of natural disasters and other emergencies occurring on their territory.¹ However, in contexts where national response or coordination capacity is unable to meet needs in a manner that respects the humanitarian principles,² or where response and coordination gaps exist due to a sharp deterioration or significant change in the humanitarian situation, there may be a need for coordination that is supported by the Inter-Agency Standing Committee.³

For the past twenty years, this coordination has primarily taken the form of sectoral “clusters” at both national and subnational levels, supported by inter-cluster coordination mechanisms to ensure overall coordination in an integrated and multisectoral way. Over time, more diversified models of coordination have evolved and, following the 2025 funding crisis and ongoing systemic changes and reforms, including the Humanitarian Reset, there is an increasing shift towards more flexible, contextualised, and multi-sector coordination models, including area-based coordination (ABC) and hybrid models.

The following Terms of Reference (TOR) are designed to support operations that are adopting ABC that falls under the remit of the IASC – namely, where national response or coordination capacity is unable to meet needs in a manner that respects the humanitarian principles, or where response and coordination gaps exist due to a sharp deterioration or significant change in the humanitarian situation.⁴ The TOR offers a working draft that can be adapted to specific humanitarian operations as needed. They outline the purpose, roles, responsibilities, and functions of ABC structures and were developed in consultation with key humanitarian stakeholders to capture operational perspectives and good practices across different humanitarian operations. Operations that have already adopted ABC approaches are not required to realign their TORs to this document.

In general, ABC and clusters are not mutually exclusive. ABC models should not replace the cluster coordination system but co-exist with it, so that different coordination tools can be leveraged to respond to operational needs in each context.

These TORs do not yet fully tackle a number of important questions on which inter-agency discussions are ongoing at the time of dissemination, including:

- Understanding the interlinkages, and respective value-add, of ABC and clusters/sectors (noting also that ABC and clusters/sectors can be complementary, including at sub-national level).
- Clarifying the links between ABC and other humanitarian structures (e.g. the HCT), functions (e.g. Provider of Last Resort), and processes (e.g. the Humanitarian Programme Cycle).
- Identifying how best to ensure coherence in service delivery sectors where services are managed as a system across different localities.

¹ United Nations General Assembly resolution 46/182

² There are, for example, now an estimated 204 million people living in areas controlled or influenced by non-state armed groups, according to the [ICRC](#), who may face challenges accessing government-provided services, assistance and support.

³ See the 2015 [Cluster Coordination Reference Module](#) for more detail on activation.

⁴ These Terms of Reference are based upon work carried out by the Global Cluster Coordination Group (GCCG), in consultation with an array of actors, and build upon the findings of the GCCG-commissioned consultancy on Area-Based Coordination, which was financed by OCHA and UNICEF.

- Clarifying expected resources for ABC (including on information management) and modalities for resourcing.
- How to link area-based coordination to local authorities, development, durable solutions, peacebuilding actors, and associated structures, in a conflict-sensitive manner.

Once there is agreement on the above questions, these TORs will be updated. In the meantime, recognizing that many operations are already establishing ABC structures for the purposes of humanitarian coordination, these TORs aim to offer a minimum common point of reference.

1. Definition

For the purposes of humanitarian coordination under the IASC, area-based coordination (ABC) is defined as a light, operational coordination and response structure or mechanism focused on a distinct subnational geographic area.⁵ It is chaired by an organisation which is present in the geographic area and has the capacity to coordinate other actors to deliver a humanitarian response that is principled⁶, accountable, well-coordinated, and context-specific. At its core, ABC is multi-sectoral and participatory, ensuring the subnational response is tailored to local needs. An ABC group is linked to relevant IASC coordination structures in the country⁷, ensuring alignment with, and support from, the wider in-country coordination system. It is primarily focused on coordinating the identification of needs, protection risks, and the delivery of goods and services in response to priorities and preferences of affected people. It also leads operational humanitarian planning relevant to that geographic area and contributes to national strategic planning (i.e. HNRP).

2. Defining features

ABC can take different forms⁸ based on the context, but it has some defining features, namely it:

- Promotes the leadership and engagement of local actors in the coordination process, capitalizing and augmenting their capacity, while ensuring this is approached in a conflict-sensitive manner.
- Is aimed at ensuring the delivery of humanitarian assistance and protection in a manner that adheres to humanitarian principles, international law (IHL and IHRL), and based on Accountability to the Affected Populations.
- Coordinates humanitarian response geographically by bringing together frontline responders across sectors within a defined subnational area to deliver a multi-sectoral response during the period for which the area is prioritised for humanitarian response.
- Supports partners to rapidly scale and adapting response to shifting needs, risks, dynamics, and access.
- Reports service delivery disruptions in non-commoditized sectors such as health.
- Ensures local needs are met holistically through multisectoral, integrated and community-centred assessments and interventions that reflect the priorities and feedback of affected populations.
- Ensures inclusive, multisectoral, and community-driven coordination.

⁵ Usually, administrative levels two to four. ABC can be at the district of a capital; the district in a rural area; an entire province, etc. Depending on its span, it may function slightly differently.

⁶ The four are: humanity, neutrality, impartiality, and independence.

⁷ For example a national-level ICCG (or a subnational ICCG if present). Historical arrangements may exist which have ABC structures reporting to other humanitarian coordination bodies.

⁸ An indicative list of different models can be found in Annex 1.

- Supports multisectoral action to address protection risks and achieve protection outcomes at area level, in line with the Centrality of Protection.
- Calls upon the Clusters, where established, to leverage their added value and resources.

3. Establishment

The HC and HCT determine the coordination structure needed for a particular context and for the requirements of the crisis, building on existing structures wherever feasible and appropriate. Key considerations include: the scale and size of the response; the complexity of the context; conflict or disaster escalations, existing protection risks, large-scale and / or protracted displacement, or other response requirements that require a conflict-sensitive, localised, and devolved operational approach to effectively address needs. If a humanitarian ABC structure already exists outside of the IASC humanitarian architecture, the HC and ABC lead/co-leads should discuss connections with and expected accountability and support to/from IASC structures in the country. Where clusters are activated, linkages and roles/ responsibilities should be clearly mapped out.

3.1. Establishment criteria

The following minimum conditions should be considered for the establishment of an ABC group:

- Significant multi-sectoral humanitarian needs and protection risks are concentrated within a clearly defined geographic area.
- There is a need for coordination of multiple actors involved in the humanitarian response to ensure a coherent and efficient response.
- Coordination needs are not covered by other mechanisms.
- At least one organisation has the capacity and willingness to chair or co-chair the group.
- The area is prioritised for humanitarian response.
- Where existing multi-sector coordination mechanisms already exist and adhere to humanitarian principles, these should be strengthened and adapted rather than establishing new ABC structures.

3.2. Selection of (Co-)Chair(s)

The Chair (or Co-Chairs) should represent an organisation with sustained physical presence and capacity to coordinate in the defined area. Selection is based on:

- Ability to convene partners, facilitate inclusive coordination, ensure coordination is carried out in a neutral manner (i.e. on behalf of all partners and not in the interests of any single organisation), and liaise effectively with other humanitarian coordination structures.
- Ability and willingness to coordinate a response, conflict sensitivity, and ability to operate neutrally across actors in a manner that adheres to humanitarian principles.
- Acceptance and trust from local actors and partners, and ability to engage with local authorities.
- Physical presence or sustained operational presence in a given geographic location.

Leadership and co-leadership should be by national and local NGOs by default, where feasible and based on operational presence and capacity. Strong representation of NGOs in leadership/co-leadership roles is critical. The respective roles of chairs and co-chairs should be clearly defined in-country to ensure equity in the sharing of administrative and secretarial responsibilities. Where an international organisation or actor serves as a Co-Chair, they will be expected to provide

capacity building support to facilitate the eventual handover of coordination to a national or local actor.

It is recommended that a call for Expressions of Interest be opened for co-chairing, with voting then carried out among operational actors/ABC participants in the relevant geographical area. The HC/HCT, in consultation with the ICCG, reviews and endorses the (Co-)Chair(s). Transparency in the selection process is critical for trust and buy-in of the coordination structure.

3.3. Key steps (for the HC and HCT, supported by the national or sub-national ICCG)⁹

- Review existing humanitarian coordination structures at national and sub-national level to identify overlaps, gaps, or duplications.
- Define the geographic scope, and the expected duration of the ABC and adjust it over time as the response evolves.
- Use HNRP geographic prioritisation and/or updated HCT prioritisation in response to crises that emerge after the finalisation of the HNRP (e.g. earthquake) to identify the need for a geographically focused humanitarian coordination mechanism.
- Assess any accessibility issues—including language, connectivity, mobility, security, or other participation barriers—that need to be addressed to enable full participation by relevant partners, and take measures to remove/mitigate them (e.g. interpretation/translation, data credit vouchers, use of preferred/secure online platform and communication means).
- Define information-sharing, consultation, feedback and escalation channels, review and endorse potential chairs/co-chairs, and set an expected duration with milestones.
- Outline the core functions and expected deliverables in a short concept note or ToR.
- Agree on the establishment of the ABC structure.
- Conduct outreach to inform, engage, and invite relevant local actors to participate, and where feasible based on operational presence and capacity, lead/co-lead ABC.

4. Functions

The ABC structure/mechanism is responsible for the following core functions within its designated area:

- **Operational coordination of multi-sectoral, efficient, humanitarian action in the specified geographic area:** Coordinates the response to humanitarian needs and protection risks in the geographic area. The ABC provides a platform for partners to collectively address operational challenges, collaboratively solving problems at the local level when possible and escalating to higher coordination levels only when necessary. It encourages the sharing of best operational practices for aid distribution across sectors. In coordination with clusters/sectors, supports service mapping to facilitate cross-sectoral referral pathways and ensure that sectoral standards defined by clusters are applied (this will ensure quality response).
- **Needs assessment, planning, and prioritisation:** Facilitates the execution of context-sensitive joint needs assessments to build a common, real-time intersectoral understanding of needs and protection risks, followed by collective integrated analysis to inform response,

⁹ As and where appropriate, these steps may be undertaken as part of the annual coordination review that every HCT is expected to carry-out.

taking into account recent and ongoing multi-sectoral and/or sectoral assessments to avoid duplication. The ABC structure facilitates regular information flow to support area-specific operational humanitarian response and planning (including contingency planning), aligned with national level plans (HNRP). Data collected or consolidated through ABCs remains part of the overall humanitarian information ecosystem, including feeding into cluster and ICCG systems. Sectoral needs analysis, sectoral severity assessment, and identification of sector-specific gaps remain the responsibility of clusters/sectors, with ABC structures contributing contextual, multisectoral, and operational insights.

- **Identification of service delivery disruptions:** Contributes to identifying and responding to the absence of, or severe constraints to public service delivery (e.g. health or water systems). This will be done in coordination with relevant and present sectoral actors including, where feasible, national, and local governments. Service gaps and priorities identified through ABC mechanisms should be shared with relevant clusters/sectors, particularly where these inform resource allocation, response scale-up, or escalation decisions.
- **Centrality of protection:** Supports the continuous area-specific situational understanding of the protection risk environment and implements action and/or advocacy to address protection risks and support protection outcomes at area-level. Aligns with national efforts on the centrality of protection (CoP), including the CoP strategy where one has been elaborated (whether separately or within the HNRP).
- **Access:** Ensures humanitarian response in the relevant geographic area reaches those with the most severe needs, and develops and implements localised access approaches and negotiations to facilitate response in geographic areas with high access constraints, together with Access Working Groups or other similar structures where appropriate.
- **Advocacy:** Provides a common platform for partners to raise key humanitarian concerns (e.g. access constraints, protection risks) at local level and to agree on how best to channel these to relevant authorities and national humanitarian structures, including clusters/sectors/systems as appropriate. Supports in analysing local risks of different advocacy approaches or initiatives.
- **Linkages and complementarity:** Wherever possible, ABCs should establish operational linkages with development, durable solutions, and peacebuilding actors to ensure complementarity between humanitarian response and other processes, including to identify opportunities for transition.
- **Engagement with authorities:** The ABC Chair or Co-Chair should engage with relevant local authorities and technical departments, in line with humanitarian principles and taking into account access and protection considerations, including to identify opportunities for transition, wherever feasible and appropriate. Engagement with local authorities by ABCs should be guided by HCT-endorsed parameters (such as Joint Operating Procedures, where they exist), informed by context analysis and risk assessments, and aligned with national-level coordination positions.
- **Accountability to affected people:** ABCs should leverage their proximity to affected communities to enhance community participation in humanitarian action. ABCs should ensure two-way communication with affected people and should systematically channel community preferences, priorities, and concerns into response planning at area-level, as well

as transmitting to ICCGs¹⁰ and HCTs, reinforcing accountability to affected people across coordination levels.

- **Protection against Sexual Exploitation and Abuse:** ABCs should undertake all possible efforts to protect against sexual exploitation and abuse (PSEA) in the relevant geographic area, including ensuring clear reporting and referral pathways.
- **Emergency response and surge coordination:** Acts as an operational hub that triggers or supports rapid responses (for example, in sudden onset disasters or conflict flare-ups), ensuring that such efforts are harmonised with ongoing activities and informed by the local context. Coordinates with any multisectoral rapid response mechanisms (RRMs) or similar emergency surge mechanisms in the area to enable timely responses to new or escalating needs.

If these functions are delivered effectively, the ABC should facilitate efficient, multi-sectoral humanitarian responses; enhanced community participation and accountability to affected people; localised ownership and leadership; improved service delivery.

5. Roles and Responsibilities of key structures/actors vis-à-vis ABC

Effective ABCs rely on clear roles among key actors:

- **ABC Chair (and Co-Chair):** Convene partners to solve problems, manage operational challenges, and coordinate the local humanitarian response. Ensure the work of the ABC feeds into national level planning and decision-making. Where the chair and/or co-chair are not national/local actors, they should proactively support capacity building of national/local actors involved in coordination to enable eventual hand over to them, and ensure succession planning is prioritised by ABC co-chairs.
- **HC and HCT:** Agree on the convening of ABC based on operational requirements, ensure alignment with national and subnational coordination including cluster/sectors, and provide strategic oversight and resource mobilisation for partners leading ABC mechanisms.
- **OCHA:** Supports the ABC, provides facilitation and information management whenever possible and subject to existing resources, and promotes coherence across ABCs, clusters/sectors, and other coordination mechanisms, including the HC/HCT and ICCG. Where designated, OCHA (co-)chairs ABC groups, ensuring consistent facilitation, information flow and connection with HCT/ICCG and subnational coordination mechanisms.
- **ICCG:** Ensures alignment with national and subnational cluster coordination, feeds ABC operational priorities into planning and funding processes, and maintains two-way information flow between subnational and national levels.
- **Cluster/Sector:** Provides sectoral technical standards and technical guidance on delivery and integrates area-level priorities into cluster strategies and coordination of actors engaged in the clusters/sectors. ABC mechanisms and clusters should agree on modalities to exchange information and align understanding of needs, risks, response, and planning.

6. Composition

The ABC structure will work in partnership with a broad range of stakeholders and with other coordination structures (including clusters/sectors) and models to avoid duplication, share

¹⁰ ICCGs at national or subnational level, or other operational coordination forums at the sub-national level.

information, and maintain coherence between area-based and national-level efforts. Membership of an ABC is context-specific and should include all key operational actors that are physically present in the defined area who are delivering a humanitarian response.¹¹ The size may vary depending on context. If a very large number of response organisations are present and participating in the ABC, this may signal a need to either review the size of the area covered by the ABC, or the choice of ABC as the most appropriate coordination modality. ABCs can also bring together local or smaller actors who may not participate in cluster coordination structures at national level and are essential to area-level response. For efficiency purposes, civil society members may decide to delegate participation to other organisations (e.g. local actor networks or representation bodies).

Typical members include those present in the area, including:

- Community-based organisations (CBOs) and civil society groups engaged in the response, including youth and women led groups, DPOs
- International NGOs and national/local NGOs
- United Nations entities
- National Societies of the Red Cross/Red Crescent Movement
- Sub-national clusters/sectors¹² (if present)

ABC should strive to include actors that are operationally relevant, and to be inclusive while at the same time remain nimble and effective. ABC mechanisms are jointly owned and reflect operational presence and capacity. Efforts should be made to avoid the ABC being seen as a space for fundraising and should focus on coordinating the responses of actors with resources who have existing response capacity. Donors, the private sector, local authorities, or others may be invited to join meetings on an ad hoc basis, while core membership remains limited to actors directly engaged in the response¹³ in order to preserve space for local and national NGOs.

7. Dissolution or transition

An ABC structure is not intended to exist indefinitely. Dissolution or transition of the ABC should be considered when one or more of the following conditions are met:

- Humanitarian needs in the area have significantly decreased or response has changed (e.g. from emergency to recovery).
- Existing coordination structures (such as government-led mechanisms) can absorb the functions of the ABC, without compromising humanitarian principles.
- The number of actors involved in humanitarian response in the area has declined to the point where a dedicated ABC group is no longer needed.
- ABC participants collectively decide that the ABC is not serving its intended purpose or another coordination model would be more effective (e.g. clusters at sub-national level). This

¹¹ Having active operations is included as a criterion to ensure that the focus of the ABC remains on coordinating operational responses to humanitarian needs and protection risks. It may include actors who do not identify as “humanitarian” provided that they are delivering programmes or interventions that aim to reduce humanitarian needs and protection risks in a manner that aligns with humanitarian principles.

¹² In some operations, they are observers and not full members of ABC structures.

¹³ Where NGO fora exist and represent operational actors participating in an ABC, they may provide technical support to NGO chairs or co-chairs and facilitate coherence between area-level structures and national coordination mechanisms, without replacing the leadership or responsibilities of the ICCG.

may be triggered, for example, by a significant/sudden increase in needs and/or response in the relevant geographic area, requiring a different coordination modality (e.g. due to there being too many partners present for ABC to function effectively etc).

An ABC (Co-)Chair, the HCT, or the HC can propose to disband the ABC or transition it to another form of coordination.¹⁴ The proposal should include justification based on the above criteria and outline a plan for addressing any remaining tasks or responsibilities by either handing them over to local authorities or development actors. The HC (after consulting the HCT) makes the final decision to disband or transition an ABC, based on evidence from assessments or operational analysis. Before an ABC is discontinued, lessons learned should be documented. If major changes in the response are expected, this should be clearly communicated to communities.

8. Relationship between ABC and cluster coordination

ABCs work in complementarity with established clusters/sectors. They do not replace sectoral coordination but facilitate integrated operational delivery at area level, drawing on technical guidance and other functions from relevant clusters/sectors. ABCs facilitate the operational coordination of multi-sector activities within a defined area, whereas sectoral standards, analysis, and strategy development remain the responsibility of the relevant clusters.

¹⁴ See IASC Cluster Transition and Deactivation Guidance (2025) for more details and suggestions.